EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Is God Too Abstract to Be Real?

Emunot VeDeot, Essay 2:Intro

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon **Essay/Chapters:** Essay 2 (the Unity of the Creator), the Introduction, and the opening of Chapter 1 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 3 June 2024, on Zoom

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: Where We Are in the Book

The Rabbi opened by placing the new essay in the structure of the whole sefer:

Stage	What Rav Saadia has done
The Introduction (eight chapters)	Laid down the basic foundations needed to understand the book: the sources of knowledge, and how we approach doubt and truth
Essay 1	Established that **there is a Creator**: that the world has a beginning, that something external brought it into being, and that it was created **from nothing**. He then went through **twelve other theories** of how the world came to be and tried to refute each one
Essay 2 (tonight)	Now that we know there is a Creator, **who and what is this Creator?** How can we describe Him and talk about His attributes?

So far, the Rabbi stressed, we have said nothing at all about what the Creator is. All we have shown is that there is one.

The Rambam follows the same order

The Rambam does exactly the same at the start of the Mishneh Torah. In Hilchot Yesodei HaTorah he does not begin with "God" or "Hashem". He begins with the **Matzui Rishon**, the First Existent, and only a few halachot later does he say that this primal being is the One we call HaKadosh Baruch Hu. Rav Saadia also first spent the whole of Essay 1 proving the existence of a first cause before saying anything about who that cause is.

Why this essay matters

Much of what Rav Saadia says in Essay 2 will sound familiar, the Rabbi said, but he is **the first to lay it out in black and white**:

- **Anthropomorphism.** He is the first to say plainly: **do not take the Torah literally** when it describes Hashem in physical terms, and he explains when we may and may not read it literally. We usually credit this to the Rambam, who fought hard against a physical understanding of Hashem, but Rav Saadia preceded him by about **200 years**.
- **The divine attributes.** If Hashem is one, how do we understand descriptions such as *Rachum* and *Chanun*, merciful and gracious, or the **Thirteen Attributes**? He does not mention it explicitly, but the same question applies to the **ten Sefirot** of the Kabbalah. These are things we have to reconcile, and Rav Saadia is the very first to discuss them.

"This is why I love this book so much. So many of the things he says are well known, but we forget who was the first one to actually lay down these principles, upon which the Rambam later worked, and many others after him."

Essay 2 has an introduction and **thirteen chapters**, all short and to the point. Tonight was the introduction.

The Point of the Introduction

Before speaking about Hashem at all, Rav Saadia makes a point about **how knowledge works**:

When we study science and work from data, the correct path is to move **from the concrete to the abstract**. All science begins with physical data in front of us. We extrapolate and build from it, and therefore **the more you understand, the more abstract it gets**.

People make the mistake of thinking that the more they know, the more concrete and tangible their knowledge should become, as if it should be "in my hands". That is not how knowledge works. Each step you learn from the one before is less concrete than the last, because you started from what you could see, and from it you are drawing out things you cannot see.

He will then explain why this principle must be understood before we discuss HaKadosh Baruch Hu and His attributes.

The Rabbi noted that the English translation in the edition the class had been using stops here, so from this point he translated the Hebrew himself.

The Principles of Knowledge

אמר המחבר: אקדים במאמר הזה לאמר, כי תחלות המדעים גסות ותכליתם דקות The author says: I will open this essay by stating that the beginnings of the sciences are coarse and their ends are fine.

The Rabbi announced that Rav Saadia lays out six principles, and listed them:

1. **The beginning of all knowledge is coarse and concrete** (*gasot*, literally "large" or "thick"), and its end is fine and subtle.
2. **Knowledge eventually reaches a final point.** There is a limit to how much the human mind can reach. Our knowledge is **finite**.
3. **Understanding goes up in levels.**

4. **Each level you go up is finer, more refined and more abstract than the one before.**
5. **The final point you reach will always be the most abstract.** When you reach it, that is what you want.

And the warning that comes with the last point: do not make the mistake of wanting the end to be concrete. "I've worked so long on this, I want to be able to touch it." If you try to do that, you are trying to go back to where you started, because you began with physical data. That **perverts the correct way of studying science**. Making the final knowledge concrete means bringing your science back down to the beginning.

Rav Saadia then says he will explain where he gets each principle from, and afterwards why he needs them here.

Principle 1: All science starts from the senses

The Rabbi stressed that at this stage we are talking about **pure science**, with no theology and no esoteric meaning. "I think this is still true today, that the scientific process necessitates starting with physical data."

- Anything **discernible to the senses** is something we can all know equally. I do not know it more than you do.
- In fact we have **no advantage over animals** here. They see and hear just as we do. What they lack is the intellect to move from the first level to the second. "Anything which is equal between humans and animals, that's the most thick, the most concrete, the most crass."
- A human begins to think about the thing he senses. Why is it sometimes black and sometimes white, sometimes hot and sometimes cold? Then he thinks about **quantity**, then **dimensions** (length, width, depth), then the **framework** in which it sits and how it interacts with other things, then **time**: how long it has existed and how long it will last.

Each step goes deeper and becomes more abstract. Just as the source was the most physical, the end product is the finest.

What is a theory? "You never call something which is sensible a theory. That would be an oxymoron. If I can touch it, it's not a theory." A theory is something I have reached in my mind and have proof for, but cannot show you to touch. The higher you go, the more theoretical and abstract your science becomes.

A debate in the class

A participant objected that in science you can eventually prove a theory physically, but here everything stays theoretical: "You never see God. There is no way you take a telescope and see God." The Rabbi answered that "we haven't said a word about God yet," and that once a theory is proven with factual data it is no longer properly a theory. How much proof turns a theory into fact is a fair question to come back to.

Principle 2: Knowledge is finite

Knowledge has a final point. Humans may never actually reach it, because no one spends long enough going deep enough, but in principle human knowledge is finite. Rav Saadia gives **three reasons**:

#	Reason
1	**Man is finite.** We are not limitless, and our intellect is one of our faculties, so it is finite too. This ties back to Essay 1, where he showed that the created universe itself is finite
2	We can only **grasp** something and call ourselves knowledgeable because it has an end. Knowledge with no end point could never be understood
3	**The main reason.** The source of all further knowledge is the senses and physical data, and **physical data is finite**. What you extrapolate cannot be greater than its source, so knowledge that starts from the finite cannot become infinite

"It may be very, very, very far, but there is a finite point where knowledge stops."

Is the universe finite?

This sparked a long discussion. One participant argued that there is no proof the universe is finite. The Rabbi disagreed: there is strong scientific evidence. "Until the 1960s people would have said what you've said, but now almost the entire scientific community accepts that the universe is expanding," as seen in the **redshift**. Something expanding has a limit at any given moment.

Others argued that what we can observe grows as our instruments improve, so we do not know where it ends. The Rabbi's reply was that "not knowing" is not the same as "infinite". We can only go by what we see, and what we know is finite.

Richard pointed out how much science has advanced, with DNA and AI. The Rabbi agreed, but said that even these are grounded in physical things. DNA is an amazing discovery, but it begins with physical cells. "We learn out incredible things from it, but it starts with something physical, and there is an end to how far you can go."

Principle 3: You climb in knowledge, not in ignorance

Knowledge has a root from which it grows, level upon level. **Ignorance is not a thing in itself.** It is simply the absence of knowledge.

The Rabbi linked this to Essay 1, where Rav Saadia held (though this is disputed, a *machloket*) that **darkness is not a creation** but simply the absence of light. In the same way, there is no creation called foolishness. Being ignorant just means not having enough knowledge. You progress in knowledge, but there are no levels of ignorance to progress through.

Rav Saadia adds that if ignorance were itself a foundation that could breed, there would be constant conflict between levels of ignorance and levels of wisdom. "I don't fully understand what he means there," the Rabbi admitted, "but I think we can accept the idea that there is progression in knowledge, but there is no progression in ignorance."

A participant compared it to **binary**: zero multiplied by a million is still zero. Put a one in front of it and you already have something. The Rabbi agreed: the moment you move out of the zero, you can build.

Principles 4 and 5: The end is always the finest. The example of snow

You look out of your window at snow falling. It looks like stones coming down: that is the crass level. Look carefully and you see it is just **hardened water**. Think further and you realise this water came from **vapour** that rose up. So the thing that looked like a stone is really vapour. Then you ask what made the vapour rise, and you keep going deeper.

The final thing is always the finest and most abstract. If you try to get to the end and want it to be physical and concrete, "you're corrupting how science works."

The principles summarised

1. All knowledge starts with the concrete and physical and moves to the abstract.
2. The knowledge we can extrapolate, one thing from the next, is finite.
3. We progress up in knowledge, but there is no progression in ignorance.
4. The higher you go, the more abstract it becomes.
5. The final point of knowledge is the most abstract, and you must not expect it to be concrete.

Why Rav Saadia Brings All This

Rav Saadia now explains why a discussion about science belongs in a book on beliefs. In Essay 1 he established that there is a Creator, yet people resist accepting it:

The objection	What they say
"I didn't see Him"	They want a Creator they can see and touch
"Too abstract"	The idea is too abstract to accept
"There's something beyond"	There must be something above this Creator: a god above the god above the god
"He's physical"	They accept a Creator but picture Him as a physical being. Others are not foolish enough to say so outright, but give Him some quality, quantity, place or time, confining Him within physical dimensions

The principles are there to remove these mistaken thoughts. The central point, which the Rabbi said runs through the whole essay and which the Rambam uses constantly:

The very fact that Hashem is so hard to comprehend shows that **you have reached the end of the path**. His abstractness does not take away from His truth. You might think that because God is so abstract He is less scientific, and therefore "less God". On the contrary: the deeper you go, the more abstract it becomes.

People say, "Science is what I can see. If I can't see it, it's not science." Rav Saadia's answer: "That's precisely the point." Anyone who says God is too abstract to believe in has stepped out of scientific discourse, because if you want to reach something concrete at the end of your scientific progress, you have missed the point.

"Deep, deep, who can find it?"

Rav Saadia brings the verse **עמק עמק מי ימצאנו**, "deep, deep, who can find it?" (Kohelet 7:24). He recalls the opinions he refuted in Essay 1, that the source of all things is something very fine, like dust, or a hair, or the indivisible atom. The Creator is above even all of these. That is the final point of knowledge.

The Rabbi called the next lines beautiful. Hashem is:

- **deeper than all that is deep,**
- **stronger than all that is strong** (*chazak mikol chazak*),
- **more hidden than all that is hidden** (*ne'lam mikol ne'lam*),
- **higher than all that is high** (*gavoah mikol gavoah*),

"until really we have no words for it." This, the Rabbi said, is almost exactly what the Rambam says two centuries later: we can only speak about God in the **negative** sense, not the positive, because He is so abstract. And Rav Saadia's message is that the abstractness should not tell you He is unreal. "The deeper something is, the more abstract it becomes."

He also brings the verses in Iyov (11:7-9):

> Can you find out the depth of God? ... Its **החקר אלוה תמצא... ארוכה מארץ מדה ורחבה מני ים** measure is longer than the earth and wider than the sea.

"There's no end to it, full stop. So beautiful."

"Can we talk about God?"

The Rabbi mentioned a talk he had given a few months earlier elsewhere with exactly that title, *Can we talk about God?* "And the answer basically was no. We can't really talk about God. We can only talk about God in a negative sense," just as with the deepest scientific theories there is a limit to how far you can go.

He reminded the class how carefully the book is structured: Essay 1, there is a Creator. Essay 2, this Creator is the one God. Essay 3, what this one God wants from us. "Saadia is very organised, very numerical, very concentrated in how he puts forward his arguments."

The Refutations

The Rabbi then turned the question to the class: based on tonight's principles, how will Rav Saadia refute those who think God is physical?

Flora answered: Hashem cannot be physical, because the deeper we go into something we thought was concrete, the less we can grasp it. "Precisely," said the Rabbi. "It's too abstract. That's exactly his point."

1. Against "God is physical"

We began with physical data and went deeper and deeper. And what do you come out with at the end? Something physical? Then you have gone back to the ABCs. We are not looking for a Creator who is basically the same as one of us. We are looking for the Creator of the entire physical universe. Anything physical you can think of, the Creator created it. **God is external, abstract, outside of everything physical.**

2. Against "there is a god above God"

Again the Rabbi asked the class, and the answer came: **knowledge is finite.** Once we have reached the Creator who is beyond, why posit more and more?

Rav Saadia anticipates a reply: perhaps knowledge is finite, but we simply have not reached its end yet, and there is a creator above the Creator still to be discovered. His answer: all data begins with the physical. Once we have left the physical and posited something abstract and external to the universe, there is nothing that would lead us on to the next step. Once we reach a Creator outside the universe, we have reached the end.

A participant added that our grasp of Hashem is limited by our own capacity. If our ability grew, we would understand more of Him. The Rabbi agreed: "We are limited." It is our ability to understand that is finite.

3. Against the "clever" version: the square root of 10,000

Then there are those who do not say outright that God has a body, but say God rests, God moves, or God gets angry. After all, the Torah says **וחרה אף ה׳ בכם**, "and Hashem's anger will flare against you." Rav Saadia says that in truth they are saying God is physical in substance, just not in so many words.

The Rabbi loved the example:

It is like someone who says: "I'm not claiming a hundred pounds from Reuven. I'm claiming the **square root of ten thousand** pounds."

He has not said the words, but it is exactly the same claim. Saying God occupies space or exists in time is the same as saying He is physical.

Why he went on at length

Rav Saadia says that although he normally likes to be brief and get to the point, he has spent time on this because these principles are foundational for the whole book and especially this essay, and understanding them now will prevent trouble later.

Summary of the refutations

Claim	Refutation
God is too abstract to be real	That is how science works. The deeper the knowledge, the more abstract
God is physical	You have gone deep only to end up back at the beginning
There is a creator beyond the Creator	Knowledge is finite. Once we have left the physical and reached something external, there is nothing beyond
God is not a body, but has space, time or emotion	The square root of 10,000 pounds: the same claim in disguise

Mitzvot: Physical Acts and an Abstract God

Chaim asked: if God is so abstract, how are our physical mitzvot connected to Him? Perhaps Rav Saadia started from the physical in order to show the road in between.

The Rabbi said Rav Saadia will discuss later why we have mitzvot and aveirot at all. "We are physical people, we do physical activities, and how is that connected to something abstract?" His basic answer: **everything we do, we do for ourselves.** "The mitzvot are for us, never for HaKadosh Baruch Hu, and all the attributes of Hashem are all for us, not for Him."

A participant added that there is a difference between mitzvot we understand, which change our character, and those that are totally beyond us. She said that, to her, mitzvot put us in **harmony with the world**, and through that harmony we connect to God. Another participant asked whether the word *mitzvah* means "to join". The Rabbi said it was a beautiful point made by **Rav Dessler**: the simple meaning is "commandment", but the root is related to the Aramaic **צוותא** (*tzavta*), togetherness and joining. "Precisely. Very good."

Why Is the Concept of God So Difficult?

Rav Saadia closes the introduction with one more question: why does the concept of God need so much discussion? Two reasons:

1. **The more precious something is, the more analysis it needs.** As is well known, it is easier to find glass than pearls. (A participant noted that pearls became precious because they were hard to find. "It depends where you're looking," the Rabbi conceded, "but the idea is there.")
2. **Too many people have said too many things about it,** whether because they did not understand, were not clever enough, did not pay attention, deliberately chose not to understand, or out of plain laziness. As he said at the beginning of the book, this is why the truth needs to be revealed.

"Now I've got rid of those who have these questions. Now let me talk about what we can say about God."

Chapter 1: Five Things We Can Say About Hashem

With a few minutes left, the Rabbi began Chapter 1, to be gone over again next time. He noted that the Rambam in the Mishneh Torah and the Ramchal in *Derech Hashem* also open by laying out what we can say about Hashem, and Rav Saadia does the same. What the prophets have told us is that He is:

#	Attribute	Verses the Rabbi read
1	**One**	"See now that I, I am He, and there is no god with Me"; "Hashem alone leads him" (Devarim 32). "You could quote tens of other verses"
2	**Living**	"Who of all flesh has heard the voice of the **living God**?" (Devarim 5); "Hashem is the true God, He is the **living God**" (Yirmiyahu 10:10). A living God means an **involved** God, not one who belongs only to the past
3	**Omnipotent**	Nothing stops Him. He can do anything
4	**Omniscient**	"There is no end to His understanding"
5	**Incomparable**	"There is none like You," as we say in Shacharit

As Rav Saadia promised in the Introduction, we **accept these from the prophets first, and then analyse them with the intellect**. He brings verses for each, and will then explain them philosophically.

Does God have a companion?

A participant asked whether God has a wife or a friend. Based on tonight, the Rabbi said, **no**: that would make God physical, and HaKadosh Baruch Hu is beyond anything like that. He added that the question already assumes God is male. "HaKadosh Baruch Hu isn't he or she. He's not male, he's not female." Humans need companions; that is a human concept. (He mentioned there is a Midrash along those lines and suggested discussing it offline.)

Summary

1. **Essay 1** proved there is a Creator. **Essay 2** asks who and what this Creator is. Rav Saadia is the first to set out plainly the rejection of anthropomorphism and the problem of the divine attributes, 200 years before the Rambam.
2. **Knowledge moves from the concrete to the abstract.** It begins with the senses, which we share with animals, and each level is finer than the last.
3. **Knowledge is finite,** because man is finite, because only what has an end can be grasped, and because its physical source is finite.
4. **There is progress in knowledge but not in ignorance,** which is only an absence, like darkness.
5. **The end of knowledge is the most abstract.** Wanting it to be concrete perverts science, as with the snow that turns out to be vapour.
6. **So God's abstractness is a sign of truth, not of unreality.** He is deeper than all deep, more hidden than all hidden. The Rambam would later say we can only describe Him negatively.
7. **The refutations:** too abstract (that is how knowledge works), physical (back to the ABCs), a god above God (knowledge is finite and ends once we leave the physical), and "space and time but not a body" (the square root of 10,000 pounds).
8. **Mitzvot and attributes are for us,** not for Hashem.

9. **Chapter 1:** the prophets tell us Hashem is one, living, omnipotent, omniscient and incomparable. We accept it from them, then analyse it with reason.

Coming Up

The Rabbi was away the following night, and some of the weekday classes paused around Shavuot. The Monday shiur would resume the next week with with **Essay 2, Chapter 1**: the five attributes in detail, and then the attributes of Hashem and why He has no body.

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/D9r8RAPFUhw · More shiurim: rabbikada.com